

What Israel Was Waiting For

First-century messianic hope was not one expectation but a range of them, and a crucified messiah fit none. That is the point.

ORIENTATION

Not One Hope. Many.

We tend to imagine first-century Israel holding a single, tidy job description marked Messiah, waiting for someone to match it. The sources will not let us keep that picture. The word messiah simply means anointed one, and Israel anointed kings, priests, and sometimes prophets. Some Jewish writings from the period barely mention a messiah at all. Their hope was that God himself would act, return to Zion, and set the world right.

But under Rome the hope concentrated. A people who remembered the Maccabees, who read Daniel's visions, who paid taxes to Caesar in the land God had promised them, began to ask the question with an edge. Not whether God would send a deliverer, but when, and what kind. The Gospels are written inside that question. When crowds ask Jesus if he is the one, they are not being curious. They are checking him against hopes they have carried for generations and paid for in blood.

THE KING

The Son of David

The dominant hope was royal. God had promised David a son whose throne would be established forever, and the prophets kept that promise alive through exile and occupation. Isaiah's shoot from the stump of Jesse. Jeremiah's righteous Branch. A king who would do what kings are for, defeat Israel's enemies and rule in justice.

We have a remarkable window into how that hope sounded on the street. The Psalms of Solomon, written after Pompey violated the temple in 63 BC, contain a prayer that is almost a manifesto. Psalm of Solomon 17 asks God to raise up the king, the son of David, to shatter unrighteous rulers, purge Jerusalem of gentiles, and gather a holy people. It is devout, biblical, and frankly military.

Hold that psalm in your mind and listen again to blind Bartimaeus shouting Son of David on the Jericho road, or to the Palm Sunday crowd waving branches, the symbol of the Maccabean victory. They are not

greeting a gentle teacher. They are welcoming a warhead.

THE RANGE

Priest, Prophet, Son of Man

The royal hope was not the only one. The Qumran community expected two messiahs, a priestly messiah of Aaron alongside the royal messiah of Israel, because in their view the throne and the altar both needed cleansing. Others waited for the prophet like Moses promised in Deuteronomy 18, which is why the priests ask John the Baptist whether he is the prophet, and why the Samaritan woman expects a messiah who will explain all things.

And there was Daniel 7, the vision of one like a son of man coming with the clouds to receive everlasting dominion. The Similitudes of 1 Enoch developed that figure into a heavenly judge, hidden with God before the worlds. When Jesus answers the high priest by joining Daniel 7 to Psalm 110, he is not being vague. He is reaching for the highest shelf in the entire library.

These hopes were not academic. Josephus and Acts both record the claimants, Theudas, the Egyptian, Judas the Galilean. Each gathered followers. Each ended in Roman violence. The century after Jesus ended the same way, when the revolt of Bar Kokhba was crushed in AD 135.

THE SCANDAL

A Contradiction in Terms

Now set every version of the hope side by side. The Davidic king conquers. The priestly messiah purifies. The prophet gathers. The Son of Man is enthroned. Every script ends in vindication. Not one ends on a Roman cross.

Crucifixion was Rome's loudest sentence, reserved for slaves and rebels, and it carried a theological verdict too. Deuteronomy says a man hanged on a tree is under God's curse. A crucified messiah was therefore not a paradox to ponder. It was a contradiction in terms, a failed messiah by definition. Paul says it plainly. A stumbling block to Jews, foolishness to gentiles. The two disciples on the Emmaus road say it with grief. We had hoped that he was the one to redeem Israel. Had hoped. Past tense.

This is why no historian thinks the early church invented its central claim. You do not recruit in the first century by announcing that your king was crucified. Something happened that forced them to say it anyway, and to call the curse a victory.

WHY IT MATTERS

Reading the Gospels Inside the Hope

Read the Gospels inside this expectation and strange details come into focus. Jesus' reluctance about the title messiah is not modesty. The word was loaded, and it would have detonated the wrong revolution. He silences confessions, withdraws when crowds want to make him king, and accepts the title openly only when it can no longer be misread as a call to arms, on trial, hours from the cross, where Rome nails it above his head as a joke that tells the truth.

He did not fail the job description. He rewrote it, joining the conquering Son of Man of Daniel to the suffering servant of Isaiah, two figures no one in the surviving literature had thought to merge into one man. The first Christians then went back to their Scriptures and found the pattern everywhere they had not looked.

Before I judge the crowd that wanted a sword instead of a cross, I should sit with my own prayers. I still hand God a job description. I still measure his faithfulness by my expectations and call the gap disappointment. Israel waited four hundred years and did not recognize the answer when it stood in front of them. I have no reason to assume I would have done better. That recognition is where reading the Gospels begins.

KEY TEXTS

2 Samuel 7:12-14

Daniel 7:13-14

1 Corinthians 1:22-23

SOURCES

The New Testament and the People of God — N.T. Wright

Lord Jesus Christ: Devotion to Jesus in Earliest Christianity — Larry W. Hurtado

Judaism: Practice and Belief, 63 BCE-66 CE — E.P. Sanders

Jesus and the God of Israel — Richard Bauckham